

Population growth



Modern concerns about our planet's capacity to support an ever-rising population hark back to the prediction of English demographer Thomas Malthus in the 18th century that England's prosperity was threatened by population growth. He argued that higher living standards could never be sustained. Firstly, they would cause a lower death rate because people would be better nourished. Secondly, they would allow people to have more children. The result would be an ever-increasing population. With more people on a fixed amount of land, food production would not be able to keep up and living standards would decline, dooming people to subsistence or worse.

Of course, Malthus's prediction didn't come to pass, because technological improvements in England allowed more food to be produced so that both living standards *and* population grew. Today, some very poor countries do seem to be caught in a

Malthusian trap in which higher population translates into poverty. However, the richest nations exited it long ago.